

Every campus is booby-trapped to snag your money: dorm-room upgrades, campus bars, takeout places, convenient bookstores, and the need to look your best among your peers.

If you answered A, try to live a little. Deprivation can also breed resentment, so enjoy the odd meal out and treat yourself when you hit those academic benchmarks.

If you answered B or C, you're keeping your eye on your cash flow, and that's good. Say no to big-ticket items like a car or a big-screen TV, and keep your spending proportionate to your input. We all know the stories of student loans financing spring break vacations and new iPads. That's how you graduate with crippling debt as opposed to manageable debt.

If you answered D, listen carefully: College is not an excuse to abuse people's generosity. Nor is it an excuse to foolishly spend your loan or your parents' income. College is the worst time to create more of that dreaded Ghost Money.

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Postsecondary education is one of the most important investments you'll ever make. Going to college because you have nothing better to do, or just because your friends are going, is a foolish waste of money. Get serious about it or delay until you know exactly what you want to study, where you should go, how you'll earn money when you're there, and how to increase your chances of getting a job when you graduate. This isn't about continuing the party that started in high school. It's about laying the groundwork for your financial future.